Understanding Sponsorship Effects

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ABSTRACT

This article offers a framework for understanding the effects of commercial sponsorship on consumers. It defines and explores certain tenets essential to understanding sponsorship effects, namely, goodwill, image transfer, and the concept of fan involvement, and relates these tenets to the achievement of a consumer response, building to a proposed model of how sponsorship "works" in relation to consumers.

Commercial sponsorship represents one of the most rapidly growing areas of marketing activity today. Although examples of corporate sponsorship were evident in many economies over 100 years ago, the scale was small, the incidence rare, and the motives often a mixture of patronage and personal fulfillment by corporate owners as patrons. However, the last three decades have seen the development of a more concerted commercial version of sponsorship, which is increasingly pragmatic in business terms, greater in scale, and globally practiced (Meenaghan, 1998a). Largely used today by corporations as a method of marketing communications, the scale and recent growth in commercial sponsorship is shown by the fact that sponsorship expenditure in the United Kingdom increased from £4 million in 1970 (Buckley, 1980) to $1075 million in 1997 (Sponsorship Research International, 2000). In the U.S. market, corporate investment in sponsorship has grown from $850 million in 1985 to an estimated 2000 expenditure of $8.7 billion (International Event Group, 2000), while sponsorship expenditure

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worldwide increased from $2 billion in 1984 to $23.16 billion in 1999 (Sponsorship Research International, 2000). These data of sponsorship expenditure only include the direct costs of securing the property rights to sponsor the activity. It is commonly agreed that a sum at least equivalent to the direct costs must be expended in leveraging/exploiting the sponsorship rights purchased.

The current scale of investment in sponsorship is substantial, as is the growth in its relative importance as a method of marketing communications, clearly evidenced by the following facts:

- On a worldwide basis, sponsorship as a percentage of advertising expenditure increased from 2.5 to 3% in 1987 (Otker & Hayes, 1987) to 7.0% in 1999; in countries such as France and Italy, it is currently valued at 9.5 and 13.2%, respectively (Sponsorship Research International, 2000). The growth dynamic of sponsorship is further indicated by the fact that it has exceeded both media advertising and promotions in terms of year-to-year growth in expenditure over the last decade (IEG, 2000).
- Sponsorship has a particular importance for specific industries such as alcohol and tobacco, evidenced by Anheuser Busch and Philip Morris, each spending in excess of $135 million on sponsorship in 1998 (IEG, 1998). However, its importance beyond these sectors is shown by the fact that estimates of Coca-Cola's worldwide expenditures on the Atlanta Games were as high as $650 million (Precision Marketing, 1996), and that their expenditure on the soccer World Cup, France '98, was estimated at $250 million (Adweek, 1998). From the financial services sector, Mastercard spent an estimated $100 million on France '98, the soccer World Cup (Bank Marketing International, 1998).

RATIONALE FOR THIS ARTICLE

Despite the evident importance of this marketing phenomenon, little is known about how sponsorship works in terms of its impact on and relationship with the consumer. The purpose of this article is to examine this neglected area of marketing theory and to propose a comprehensive theoretical framework that seeks to understand the consumer's response to corporate sponsorship activity, i.e., to understand how sponsorship works. The central thrust of the proposed model is that sponsorship works differently in relation to the consumer than do other forms of advertising and promotions in that it engages the consumer differently by bestowing benefit on an activity (e.g., sports or arts) with which the consumer has an intense emotional relationship. The belief that the sponsor's investment benefits the activity generates a goodwill effect among activity fans, which in turn influences their attitude and behavior toward the sponsor's brand. The intensity with which the consumer/fan is involved with a particular activity provides a useful framework against which the concepts of goodwill, perceptions of benefit, image transfer, and related consumer response can be understood.

To date, research devoted to the topic of commercial sponsorship has largely concentrated on the profiling of management practices and the problems relating to evaluating sponsorship effectiveness. The profiling of sponsorship management practices, focusing on the motivation, choices, and behavior of sponsorship decision makers, has seen the greatest concentration of academic research, with its genesis in the early research work of Waite (1979). To date, similar type research has been carried out in most major markets (in the United States by Irwin & Sutton, 1994; Schuman, 1986; in Australia by Farrelly & Quester, 1997; Pope & Voges, 1994; Scott & Suchard, 1992; in Canada by Copeland, Frisby, & McCarville, 1996; Thwaites & Aguilar-Manjarrez, 1998; in the United Kingdom by Marshall & Cook, 1992; Thwaites, 1995; Waite, 1979; Witcher, Craigen, Culligan, & Harvey, 1991; in Ireland by Crowley, 1991; Quinn, 1982; in New Zealand by Hoek, Gendall, & Sanders, 1993; and in South Africa by Abratt and co-workers, 1987, 1989). Almost all such studies have used a relatively common research focus in terms of issues explored and methodology employed (usually in the form of a survey of sponsorship decision makers). Although useful in aiding insight into corporate decision making, this replication of research studies has meant declining returns in terms of enhanced understanding.

The second major concentration of research interest has focused on evaluating the effects of sponsorship in terms of standard recall and recognition tests—concerns and techniques imported from conventional advertising research. Although the profiling of management practices research shows that media exposure monitoring is the most widely used method of sponsorship evaluation, sponsor name awareness and sponsor association with the sponsored event are also regarded as important indicators of sponsorship effectiveness (Crimmins & Horn, 1996; Easton & Mackie, 1998; Hitchen, 1995; Kraak & Olivier, 1997; Meenaghan, 1996; Nicholls, Roslow, & Dublish, 1999; Otker & Hayes, 1987; Parker, 1991; Quester, 1997; Stotlar, 1993). Despite their considerable corporate popularity, it must be recognized that sponsor awareness and association tests are merely first-line measures of sponsorship impact, and do not of themselves serve to facilitate understanding of consumer engagement with sponsorship. Image transfer also represents a much-sought-after sponsorship objective, but image effects have received considerably less research attention than have awareness effects, and this is perhaps understandable given the more problematic nature of the image evaluation task (Ferrand & Pages, 1996; Grimes & Meenaghan, 1998; Hansen & Scotwin, 1995; Hitchen, 1995; Rajaretnam, 1994; Rajshekhar, Traylor, Gross, & Lampman, 1994; Stipp & Schiavone, 1996; Teopaco & Greyser, 1992).

More recent research on sponsorship effectiveness has sought to relate particular consumer variables such as age, gender, volume consumption of televised sport, patriotism, sport involvement, and prior attitude toward the event to effects achieved (e.g., McDaniel & Kinney, 1997) with some improvement in resulting understanding. Other research has sought to elucidate consumer response to sponsorship beyond the obvious consumer awareness and image effects. Pham (1992) sought to examine how event involvement on the part of the consumer mediated the effectiveness of exposure to sponsorship stimuli, whereas Hoek, Gendall, Jeffcoat, and Orsman (1997) examined the comparative effects of sponsorship and advertising stimuli using Ehrenberg's ATR (awareness–trial–reinforcement) model, though with relatively inconclusive outcomes. Bloxham (1998) examined consumer perceptions of broadcast sponsorship, and Kinney and McDaniel (1996) examined attitude toward the advertisement (AAD), attitude toward the brand (AB), and purchase intention as indicators of the effectiveness of Olympic sponsorship. In summary, it is true that research on sponsorship with regard to consumer response has focused on individual elements of explanation, rather than on the provision of a generalized model that might facilitate overall understanding of the phenomenon.

The net result of the research concentrations described above is that the level of understanding of consumer response to sponsorship is grossly inadequate and is in stark contrast to the current understanding of consumer response to conventional media advertising, a fact not unrelated to the cumulative level of research activity with respect to each. What is needed now is to define and to address a research agenda for sponsorship that will advance understanding of its processes and effects and set the terms of reference for future studies. The purpose of this article is to seek to address the major gap in our understanding by proposing a comprehensive model of how sponsorship works. At the outset, it is important to note that the proposed model of sponsorship effects refers to how event, rather than broadcast sponsorship works, although much of the understanding that emerges will be seen to be appropriate to the latter form of sponsorship also.[1]

[1] Event sponsorship is a collective term given to the sponsorship of various activities in the fields of sports, arts, and causes and may involve the sponsorship of teams, players/artists and competitions; broadcast (program) sponsorship refers to the sponsorship of the television or other broadcast of an event. This distinction is more marked in Europe, where broadcast sponsorship is more recent than in the United States, where sponsors of broadcast programs are often referred to as advertisers.

SOURCES OF UNDERSTANDING

The understanding upon which the proposed model is founded derives from a variety of sources including the literature (insofar as it has begun to address these issues); the author's own published work in the sponsorship field and in regard to the theoretical principles of marketing communications and advertising; long-term involvement in desk research; leading-edge sponsorship industry data; close working relationships with major sponsorship industry figures; and action learning associated with consultancy experience in the sponsorship field.

In addition, the commentary offered will draw on large-scale empirical work the author has conducted, focusing on the particular issue of consumer response to sponsorship (Meenaghan, 1994). The research design for this empirical work, which relied upon a qualitative perspective, involved two specific research interventions, namely, indepth interviews with acknowledged industry experts in the sponsorship field and focus-group research with consumers as receivers of sponsorship communications. The sponsorship industry commentator group, which included specialist international researchers, consultants, and corporate managers of sponsorship programs, articulated views on key aspects of sponsorship, including perceptions of the effects of sponsorship on consumers, whereas the focus group research sought to understand actual receiver perceptions of sponsorship.

The focus-group members included respondents with varying degrees of involvement in different sports and arts activities ranging from passionate followers to those wholly uninvolved with these activities. Focus-group discussions took place against an outline discussion guide based on an understanding achieved at earlier stages in the research process. The particular focus-group respondents were Irish nationals, and their frame of sponsorship experience was multifaceted, reflecting involvement with specifically Irish, as well as U.K., European, and worldwide games, events, teams, and players. Case examples discussed in the focus-group sessions related to all levels of the respondents' experience, and the general understanding that emerged from this research is believed not to be culturally or geographically bound. Although these research results form the basis of the model proposed, evidence available prior to and after completion of the empirical work is also discussed where appropriate. In effect, the understanding on which the proposed model is based derives from the author's immersion in a variety of data sources with particular reference to focus-group research involving consumers as receivers of sponsorship, and the descriptive model arising from this immersion is in the "thick description" mode.

THE TENETS OF UNDERSTANDING

Our understanding of how conventional advertising works depends on a number of central tenets, namely, advertising as a multistage process, with central and peripheral routes to persuasion and an active rather then passive consumer. The understanding posited as to how sponsorship works is similarly predicated on several key tenets, namely, the notion of consumer goodwill, the processes of image transfer, and the concept of fan involvement. Each of these tenets is now discussed both individually and in terms of its relationship to others, culminating in an analysis of the process by which consumers actually respond to sponsorship. This discussion builds toward a comprehensive model reflecting the interrelationships between the various tenets and themes.

- ***Goodwill in Sponsorship***
  Consumer perception of sponsorship
  The goodwill factor in sponsorship
- ***Image in Sponsorship***
  - Image effect at the sponsorship category level
  - Image effects at the individual activity level
  - Image congruence and sponsorship
- ***The Concept of Fan Involvement***
  - Segmenting the sponsorship audience
  - Sponsorship management and goodwill effects
  - The concept of contingent goodwill
- ***Consumer Response to Sponsorship***
  - Communication effects and sponsorship
  - Sponsorship and sales effects
  - Fan involvement and marketing effects

GOODWILL IN SPONSORSHIP

The first tenet of understanding focuses on the goodwill phenomenon in sponsorship. It may well be the issue that ultimately differentiates sponsorship from advertising, and it may serve as the major trigger influencing the response of consumers.

Consumer Perceptions of Sponsorship

That sponsorship is different from advertising has been a running theme in the available sponsorship literature to date (Bloxham, 1998; Hastings, 1984; Hoek et al., 1997; McDonald, 1991; Meenaghan, 1991; Stipp, 1998). One of the most forceful results arising from the author's

Comparative Factors	*Sponsorship*	*Advertising*
Goodwill	**Beneficial**	**Selfish**
Focus	**Indirect/Subtle**	**Direct/Forceful**
Intent to Persuade	**Disguised**	**Overt**
Defence Mechanisms	**Low State of Alertness**	**High State of Alertness**

Figure 1. Sponsorship/advertising—alternative communications compared.

focus-group research discussed above, was the perception of commercial sponsorship held by respondents and particularly the extent to which it is seen by receivers as being different from advertising. (For a further debate on this topic, see Meenaghan this issue.) Commercial sponsorship as a generic form of marketing communications is seen as involving benefit to society. It is seen as subtle and indirect, involving a disguised intent to persuade resulting in a lowering of consumer defense mechanisms. Advertising, by contrast, is seen as being selfish and in the interests of the advertiser, thus involving no obvious benefit to society. It is seen as forceful and coercive, leading to an alerted state of the consumer's defense mechanisms. The perceived distinctions between these two methods of marketing communications are indicated in Figure 1.

Given that consumers perceive sponsorship and advertising differently in terms of processes and outcomes, it appears that consumer receptivity to these two alternative methods of marketing communications also varies. In effect, consumers appear to receive sponsorship communications in a halo of goodwill, which is generated by factors such as the perception of benefit, the subtlety of the message, and the disguised commercial intent of the communication. The effect of this halo of goodwill is that sponsorship communications appear to encounter lowered consumer defense mechanisms. By way of contrast, advertising communications are received in a force field of skepticism and suspicion driven by factors such as the forceful nature of the communication, the obvious commercial intent and consumer beliefs about advertisers' motivation. The focus-group study demonstrates that advertising, when compared to sponsorship communications, seems to encounter consumer defense mechanisms in a heightened state of alertness.

The Goodwill Factor in Commercial Sponsorship

The notion of goodwill is central to an understanding of sponsorship. Both Meenaghan (1991) and McDonald (1991) suggested that one of the prime factors that distinguishes sponsorship from advertising was the existence of goodwill. Such goodwill was believed to be driven by the appreciation of individuals who recognize the benefits of sponsorship to activities with which they are involved (Meenaghan, 1991). The results of the focus-group research confirm the existence of the goodwill factor in sponsorship. More importantly, the results suggest that this goodwill factor exists at three different levels of aggregation, namely, sponsorship at generic level (as an activity), category level (sport, arts, etc.), and individual activity level (e.g., a basketball team), with the intensity of goodwill varying by level of aggregation.

Generic Level. As a phenomenon, commercial sponsorship is seen as delivering benefit to society, thus engendering a warmer relationship than that developed through advertising's perceived focus on transaction. The outcome is the encouragement of goodwill. At this generic level, the goodwill effect is more abstract and is less deeply felt than at other levels of aggregation, usually being expressed in terms of sponsorship being a "good idea." Consumer reaction may be explained by the fact that sponsorship at this generic level does not touch or engage with the individual consumer in a deep and meaningful way.

Category Level. The second level at which the goodwill effect was apparent is the category level (i.e., sports, arts, etc.) with differing categories of sponsorship meriting varying degrees of goodwill. For example, the sponsorship of social causes generally encourages greater goodwill toward the sponsor than does the sponsorship of mass arts. At the category level, goodwill effects are more intensely felt than at the generic level, with consumer disposition toward a particular category (e.g., the arts), encouraging greater goodwill toward sponsors of that category.

Individual Activity Level. The perception of benefit, related appreciation, and goodwill effects are generally greatest when the sponsorship benefits an activity with which the consumer is involved. At this level, goodwill effects are most apparent, being driven by the intensity of consumer involvement with that activity. A football fan may consider that sponsorship, generically, is a good thing for society and may have a positive attitude toward a sports sponsor at the category level, but the fan's response to the sponsor of the team with which he is intimately involved will be more deeply felt, obviously generating greater levels of goodwill and gratitude toward that sponsor.

IMAGE IN SPONSORSHIP

The second tenet underpinning understanding is concerned with image in sponsorship, and the discussion will now focus on three aspects,

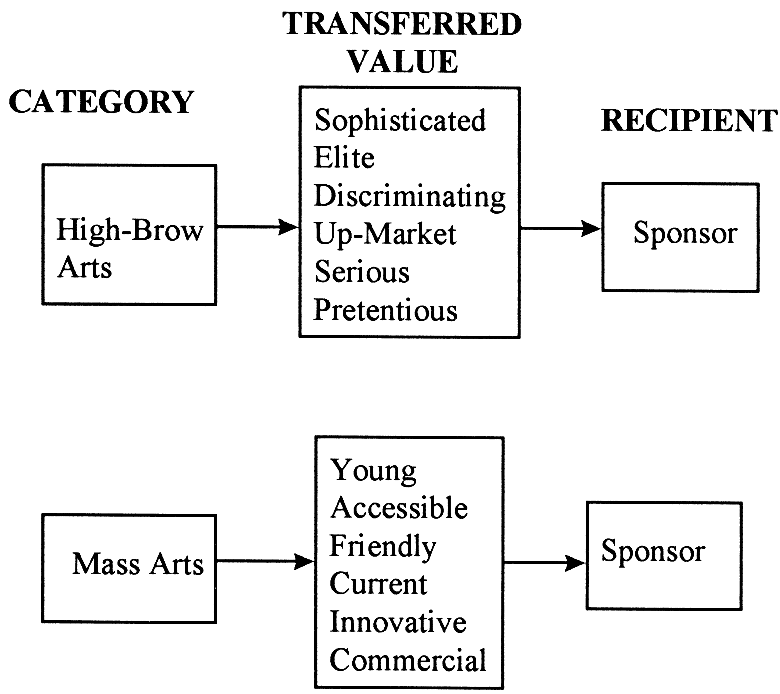

Figure 2. Image values derived from various categories of sponsorship.

namely, image at the sponsorship category level, image at the individual activity level, and image congruence and sponsorship.

Image at the Sponsorship Category Level

There is a widely established understanding in the advertising literature and in agency media planning practice that individual media (press, radio, television, etc.) possess particular qualities that affect consumer perceptions of the message delivered (Crane, 1972; Dommermuth, 1974; Grass & Wallace, 1974; Joyce, 1981; McConnell, 1970; Stewart & Ward, 1994). In the case of commercial sponsorship, the equivalent level of analysis to the "medium" in advertising is the sponsorship "category" (i.e., sports, arts, or social causes) with a parallel image effect at the sponsorship category level also suggested (Meenaghan, 1983).

The focus-group research clearly showed that different categories of sponsorship transfer different image values to the sponsor. This is indicated in Figure 2, which shows that association with highbrow arts activities such as ballet or classical music transfers the image values of sophisticated, discriminating, elite, up-market, serious, and possibly pretentious. Note that association with mass arts suggests very different image values.

Image at the Sponsored-Activity Level

Image transfer at the individual sponsored-activity level provides further insights to aid understanding of sponsorship effects. Advertising theory in terms of media-vehicle effect suggests that each particular media vehicle (e.g., Time magazine) possesses its own personality delivering specific image values. When combined with a brand in an advertising message, there is a transfer of values from the media vehicle to the brand. This transfer principle is known as media-vehicle effect in advertising studies (Aaker & Brown, 1972; Hafstrand, 1988; Joyce, 1981; Laurent, 1990; Smith, 1972), contiguity and similarity in semiotic inquiry (Mick, 1986), and symbiosis in branding research (Cooper, 1979). A variation on this theme is the notion of context effect, whereby different program contexts induce different consumer moods and receptivity to advertising messages (Gardner, 1985; Mathur & Chattopadhyay, 1991; Pavelchak, Antil, & Munch, 1985; Tavassoli, Schultz, & Fitzsimons, 1995; Woodside & Soni, 1990).

In the course of the focus-group research, respondents were asked what each of a series of sponsorship relationships "said about the sponsor?" The results confirmed that each sponsored activity has its own distinct personality and a transfer of the image values occurs from the sponsored activity to the sponsor. In effect, the results confirm the suggestion that "an individual sponsored activity is . . . possessed of a personality and there is a rub-off or halo effect to corporate or product image from association" (Meenaghan, 1983, p. 31).

Although all case examples discussed in the focus-group setting confirm this view, the case of Bank of Ireland's sponsorship of two very distinct activities is interesting in that two very different sets of image values were being transferred through these individual relationships. The GAA All-Stars sponsorship is an annual Players' Awards program for the high-profile, hugely popular Gaelic Games series in Ireland, whereas the Proms is a light classical series of concerts for both a live and television audience. The transferred image values are indicated in Figure 3.

Image Congruence and Sponsorship

Although the principle of congruence is most often articulated in terms of source and message (Osgood & Tannenbaum, 1955), it was felt that a sufficient degree of parallel application existed in the case of commercial sponsorship to merit investigation. The results of the focus-group discussions relating to this issue did indeed support the proposition that receivers perceive congruence in certain activity/sponsor arrangements. A number of important insights that provide understanding of sponsorship effects emerge from the findings.

Sponsored Activity

Sponsor	GAA All-Stars	The Proms
Bank of Ireland	Transferred Image Values	
	'Irish'	Conservative
	Traditional	High-Brow
	Rural	Corporate
	Conservative	Affluent urban
	Less Sophisticated	Up-market

Figure 3. Bank of Ireland sponsorship.

1. The ability of a consumer to perceive congruence is determined by the individual's level of knowledge concerning both parties to the relationship (i.e., sponsor and sponsored activity).
2. The central factor in determining perceptions of congruence is the extent to which consumers perceive a logical connection between both parties to the relationship (i.e., sponsor and sponsored activity). For example, dissonance rather than congruence was the experience for the product category, cigarettes and the sponsorship of athletics, but congruence was clearly present between the high-energy snack bar, Mars, and athletics.

Parallel research into consumer attitudes to broadcast sponsorship (Bloxham, 1998) suggests that congruence between the sponsor's brand and the sponsored broadcast is an important criterion in terms of consumers' evaluations. Similarly Kinney and McDaniel (1996) suggest that incongruity between event and sponsor may well retard image association between event and sponsor.

THE CONCEPT OF FAN INVOLVEMENT

A further central tenet in understanding how sponsorship works is the concept of fan involvement. As sponsorship is inevitably concerned with activities and events with which consumers are involved as fans, the concept of fan involvement itself is the subject of an extensive sociological and sports management literature and is now examined in a marketing and sponsorship context.

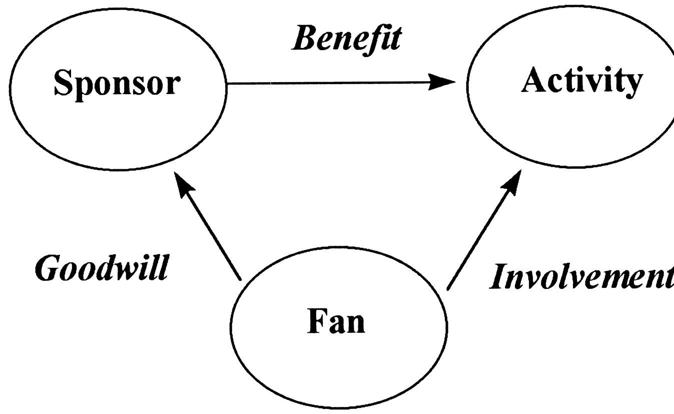

Figure 4. Goodwill effects and fan involvement.

The Concept of Fan Involvement

Fan involvement refers specifically to the extent to which consumers identify with, and are motivated by, their engagement and affiliation with particular leisure activities. The phenomenon of fan involvement provides a powerful explanation of social behavior as witnessed in the adulatory responses to rock music stars and the fanatical loyalty of sports fans. Indeed, the phenomenon of fan involvement has been the subject of considerable research endeavor in the fields of sports behavior (Cialdini and co-workers, 1980, 1989; Sloan, 1989; Spinrad, 1981; Wann & Brancombe, 1993; Zillman & Paulus, 1993) and popular music (Arnett, 1995; Ehrenreich, Hess, & Jacobs, 1992; Frith, 1978; Grossberg, 1992a, 1992b; Longhurst, 1995; Lull, 1987).

Fan involvement can help to explain the very different reactions of consumers to individual sponsorships as compared to advertisements in that sponsorship impinges upon consumers in a very different manner. The focus-group discussions showed that sponsorship intervenes in an emotional relationship between consumers and their leisure/social activities. In doing so, the sponsor embarks on a potentially brittle, yet rewarding, relationship with followers of the activity, and this has major implications for the corporate management of sponsorship, the generation of goodwill, and related image effects.

In a sponsor/sponsored-activity relationship there is positive emotional orientation toward the sponsor who bestows benefit on the consumer's favored activity. This is mediated by the intensity of fan involvement and in turn forms the basis of consumer reaction to the sponsor (Meenaghan, 1998b). This triangular relationship between sponsor, activity, and fan is indicated in Figure 4.

More recently, Bloxham (1998), in researching broadcast sponsorship in Europe, found that the broad principles of fan involvement, fan knowledge, perception of benefit, and goodwill also apply to television program sponsorship.

> Salience plays a part in getting across the brand image, but equally important are the viewer's emotional attachment and loyalty to a programme, which in turn may create emotional bonding with the brand if the sponsor's contribution is perceived as benefiting the programme. (p. 94)

Segmenting the Sponsorship Audience

Segmenting the activity audience has received only limited attention in a sponsorship context. The segmentation of audiences on a volume consumption basis (e.g., heavy and light users of live or televised sports) provides a convenient basis for addressing activity followers in a sponsorship context (Eilander & Koenders, 1991; Kirban, 1985; Research Services Ltd., 1990). However, such volume segmentation fails to appreciate the deeper levels of sport involvement, which strongly influence varying consumption patterns. More recently, some researchers (Pham, 1992; Shani & Sandler, 1998) have begun to employ the concept of fan involvement in sponsorship studies, and although such research indicates an interesting area for future study, it must be questioned whether the deployment in such studies of dimensional measures such as "care" and "importance" has the capacity to capture the essence of the relationship between the fan and his or her beloved sport. It is this author's belief that other constructs must be developed to capture the intense passion, loyalty, despair, elation, and often lifelong (even intergenerational) relationship fans may have with their preferred teams, players, and sports.

Undoubtedly fan involvement is a useful construct in understanding the effects of sponsorship on consumers. In sponsoring a particular activity, the sponsor is gaining access to a particular market. Each sponsored activity (whether rock act or soccer team) creates its own audience and therefore provides access to a given segment of the total population. However, the activity audience is not itself homogeneous in terms of degree of interest or involvement. For example, loyalty among fans of a football team may vary from highly involved individuals to those only marginally committed. These basic segmentation principles are identified in Figure 5.

Sponsorship Management and Image Effects

An understanding of fan involvement and the impact of sponsorship management decisions on both goodwill and sponsor image effects became an issue in the focus-group discussions referred to previously. In-

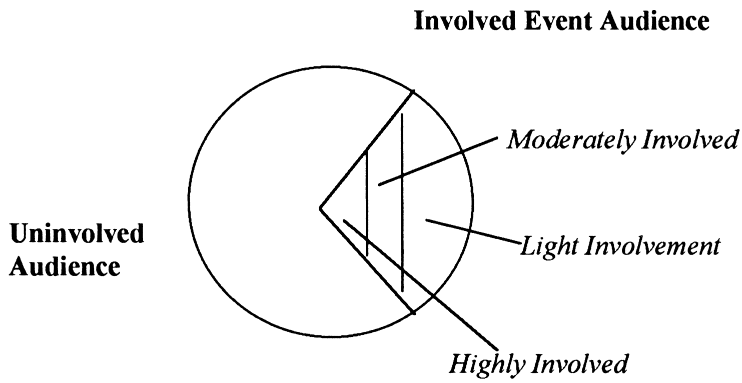

Figure 5. Segmenting the sponsorship audience.

dividual sponsorship management decisions such as sponsorship selection and sponsorship exploitation were discussed in order to understand how the behavior of the sponsor toward the sponsored activity affects goodwill and image effects.

Image and goodwill generation can be affected by the timing of entry to the sponsorship, where late arrivals to sponsoring an activity may be regarded as "bandwagon" sponsors, whereas early sponsors may attract warmer appreciation and gratitude. The level of commitment displayed by the sponsor throughout the sponsorship can similarly attract an additional quotient of goodwill. The display of commitment should normally involve a relationship between the sponsor and the activity that is seen to go beyond mere commercial concerns and shows a level of care for the activity that will be rewarded by an extension of a sense of inclusion on the part of fans. Thus, affinity is developed with the sponsor and gratitude and goodwill flow in the sponsor's direction. The problem of exiting from a sponsorship must be carefully managed to minimize damage to the goodwill created and to preserve such goodwill wherever possible, for it is at the point of exit that the risk of being seen to be merely exploiting the activity is probably greatest.

Consumers are quite literate about sponsorship, being mature enough to know that there must be a return to the sponsor for the investment; yet, they are sensitive to the potential for sponsor abuse. This sensitivity to sponsor exploitation is most marked among committed activity fans, who applaud positive sponsor actions and (in return) accord greater goodwill, whereas perceived excessive exploitation may encourage hostility among highly involved fans. Those with little or no activity involvement do not register sponsor exploitation to the same degree and therefore accord little goodwill/hostility to the sponsor other than to be offended in a disengaged way by overt abuse of an activity. The evidence of the focus-group research in relation to exploitation is paralleled by Bloxham's (1998) findings that viewers of broadcast sponsorship react negatively to excessive sponsor intrusion into sponsored programs.

The Concept of Contingent Goodwill

Although the generation of consumer goodwill is an obvious sponsor objective in undertaking a sponsorship program, the foregoing discussion suggests that there is a need for sponsors to strategically consider the management of goodwill as an issue in itself. It is clear that a range of individual sponsor management decisions impact upon the sponsor's image, and particularly upon the nature, intensity, and direction of flow of goodwill. The contingencies involved include the sponsorship choice, the time of entry, the time and manner of exiting, the level of overt sponsor commitment, the nature of caring displayed toward the activity and its fans, and finally the interplay between these factors. The notion of contingent goodwill in effect means that goodwill is earned by the total behavior of the sponsor toward all aspects of the sponsored activity and this is registered and judged by fans of that activity. Perceived benefit is rewarded with strong feelings of respect and affinity for the sponsor, while perceived abuse generates hostility. These effects are greatest among those most involved with the sponsored activity, and in general, these consumers are most likely to be the identified target group for the sponsorship program.

In order to maximize the goodwill effects, the sponsor must strive to be seen as a "good" sponsor whose relationship with the activity results in benefit to the activity. When entering upon a sponsorship program, the sponsor engages in an overt contract with the event owner. However, it is strategically crucial that the sponsor also recognize that there is an unspoken social contract with activity followers which commits the sponsor to behave within formally unspecified, but nonetheless real boundaries of behavior. The sponsored activity does not provide the sponsor with an unfettered opportunity for publicity purposes. The goodwill of fans is a matter of will which cannot be bought, but must be earned. In the context of this delicate relationship, actions that are seen to benefit the activity are rewarded with goodwill, whereas transgressions, such as excessive exploitation, are punished with negative attitudes toward the sponsor, defeating the sponsor's original motivation for investment. The unspoken understanding between the sponsor and the activity followers is both contingent and highly fragile and the reactions of the activity follower are conditional on the sponsor's respect for the sanctity/integrity of the activity. Clearly, there is a framework of uncodified rules regarding trespass that is central to the understanding and management of sponsorship effects.

CONSUMER RESPONSE TO SPONSORSHIP

The article has discussed the role of sponsorship in goodwill generation, image transfer, and the extent to which sponsorship management decisions are mediated through fan involvement. Given that the primary motivation for sponsorship investment is the achievement of a consumer response, this article will now consider the communications and sales effects arising from sponsorship involvement.

The Communications Effects of Sponsorship

The earlier discussion on segmenting the sponsorship audience identified the importance of involvement as the key variable distinguishing activity followers. Fundamentally the communication effects of sponsorship vary according to the degree to which the individual consumer is involved with the sponsored activity.

In the case of the uninvolved audience, the effects of sponsorship are quite limited. At best this group is likely to register an abstract goodwill toward the sponsor. If the particular activity or event grows in national or international prominence, then sponsor name registration and sponsor image effects may be achieved with such a group. However, the intensity with which such effects are achieved will always be less than that experienced by committed fans.

In the case of the involved audience, several levels of communications effects arising from sponsorship can be detected, and these are broadly similar to the multistage process central to our understanding of advertising effects. The focus-group research showed that awareness of the sponsor is highest among those most involved with the activity, and this is in line with evidence presented by Bennett (1999), Clark (1991), Diakopoulou (1990), Eilander and Koenders (1991), and Parker (1990, 1991). Highly involved fans/consumers, being most aware of the sponsor's investment and the benefit arising, are most favorably disposed toward that sponsor, and the results of the current study in this regard accord with the evidence presented by Clark (1991), Diakopoulou (1990), McDonald (1991), and Parker (1990, 1991). Indeed, recent research by the International Olympic Committee (1997) showed that although 30% of respondents felt more favorable toward a company because it was an Olympic sponsor, this result rose to 45% for fans whose commitment was defined by their attendance as spectators at the Atlanta Olympic Games.

Activity followers, being most knowledgeable of the image values embodied in the activity, transfer these specific image values to the sponsor. In short, media-vehicle effect in sponsorship situations is most clearly present among those most involved with the activity. The focus-group findings on this matter are in line with those reported by Kohl and Otker (1985), following their examination of the Philips CD sponsorship of the 1984/1985 world concert tour of the rock band Dire Straits. Using pre- and post-research waves the researchers found that the desired image dimensions of "sound quality" and "sophisticated technical features" achieved substantially increased levels of transfer among hi-fi freaks and males aged 14–39 years (to whom the image values embodied in Dire Straits were most apparent). Similarly, research undertaken on behalf of Mastercard (1994 Soccer World Cup) clearly indicate that the transfer of image values associated with the event is substantially higher among respondents aware of the sponsor's involvement than among respondents unaware of the sponsor's involvement (Sponsorship Research International [SRi], 1998).

Sales Effects and Sponsorship

The focus-group research revealed interesting aspects of the relationship between sponsorship and sales effects, and these sales effects can be examined at several points along the buying continuum (i.e., purchase intent, brand preference, and claimed purchase).

Among those focus-group respondents who were highly involved with an activity and to whom the benefit of the sponsorship was most apparent, the level of goodwill/gratitude was such that respondents expressed a strong preference for the particular sponsor's product. This finding is confirmed by several other research studies (Bennett, 1999; Eilander, 1992; Kohl & Otker, 1985). Indeed, the latter study found that purchase intention among hi-fi freaks (knowledgeable about Dire Straits music) increased for Philips compact disc players as a result of the Philips sponsorship of Dire Straits. In a similar vein, recent research showed that Olympic Sponsorship increased consumers purchase propensity (International Olympic Committee [IOC], 1997). In a nine-country study, 22% of consumers on average were more likely to purchase an Olympic sponsor's brand, but this rose to 33% for spectators at the Atlanta Games, as they can be assumed to be more committed fans.

Recent research in the U.S. market (Hitchen, 1998) compared the effects of sponsorship on fans and nonfans of NASCAR racing and the NFL. Committed fans of both sports were twice as likely as nonfans to have switched brands as a result of sponsorship. Furthermore, fans were more than twice as likely to remain brand loyal to the sponsor of their sport compared with nonfans.

In the case of some focus-group respondents, the level of gratitude toward and affinity with the sponsor led to the claimed purchase of the sponsor's brand. Examples of this were evident in Body Shop's sponsorship of green and eco-friendly campaigns and the effect such image positioning had on environmentally concerned consumers. A further instance was the case of Lucozade, an energy drink, and athletics fans. It is noteworthy that in all instances where purchase was claimed, the product category was classically one which the traditional marketing literature would describe as low involvement (Engel, Blackwell, & Miniard, 1993; Finn, 1984; Laurent & Kapferer, 1985; Zaickowsky, 1994). Indeed with regard to involvement, Gwinner (1997) suggested that "when the sponsoring brand is a low involvement product, event image will be a potent force in determining brand attitude" (p. 154) (though no suggestions were made with regard to purchase). In the focus-group setting, where the sponsor's brand involved a classic high-involvement marketing situation (e.g., cars), gratitude toward the sponsor among those closely involved with an activity led to the fan being predisposed towards the sponsor's output, but no claims of purchase arising from the sponsor's program were made by even the committed fans.

Research on this topic often reports that sponsorship acts as the catalyst in triggering purchase. For example, a major survey of British respondents (SRi, 1995) indicated that 9% of respondents claimed to have tried a sponsor's brand for the first time because of sponsorship, and 7% claimed to have switched brands for the same reason. However, the research results discussed in this section clearly indicate that the effects of sponsorship are significantly greater among those most highly involved with an activity. A recent NOP survey of 1000 U.K. adults (Baird, 1998), coinciding with the soccer World Cup, France '98, provides an appropriate summary of the differential impact of sponsorship on consumers arising from their involvement with sponsored activities. As can be seen from Figure 6, the communication and sales effects of sponsorship are significantly higher among those identified as "very interested" in the soccer World Cup.

Fan Involvement and Consumer Response

It is possible to synthesize the foregoing discussion in diagrammatic form, and to this end the interaction of levels of fan involvement and consumer response are illustrated in Figure 7. Highly involved fans, being most knowledgeable, are most sensitive to benefit/abuse, and therefore are most likely to experience goodwill or its converse. As the most knowledgeable group they are highly aware of the sponsor, and if satisfied by the sponsor's behavior toward the activity, they tend to be favorably disposed toward the sponsor. Being most involved they are best placed to apprehend the image values inherent in their preferred activity and most capable of transferring these values to the sponsor through association. Consumers who are highly involved activity followers are thus likely to be prime sales prospects for the sponsor's products. In the case of low-involvement products, actual purchasing by activity followers may take place. In the case of high-involvement products, the extent to which favorable sponsor disposition influences actual purchase of the sponsor's product remains unclear from available research.

	% All Adults	% Very Interested
All adults	100	26
Spontaneous awareness of any sponsor	55	80
Incorrect attribution of sponsor	67	56
Spontaneous advertising awareness	40	53
Any involvement with promotions	30	48
Buying newspapers or magazines particularly for the World Cup supplement or coverage	18	35
Buying a product because of a World Cup pack or promotion	11	20
Collection schemes run by retailers/ manufacturers	9	13
Competitions on pack or products	7	13
Food or drink bought	11	20
Clothing or footwear bought	8	12

Figure 6. Marketing effectiveness of World Cup Links.

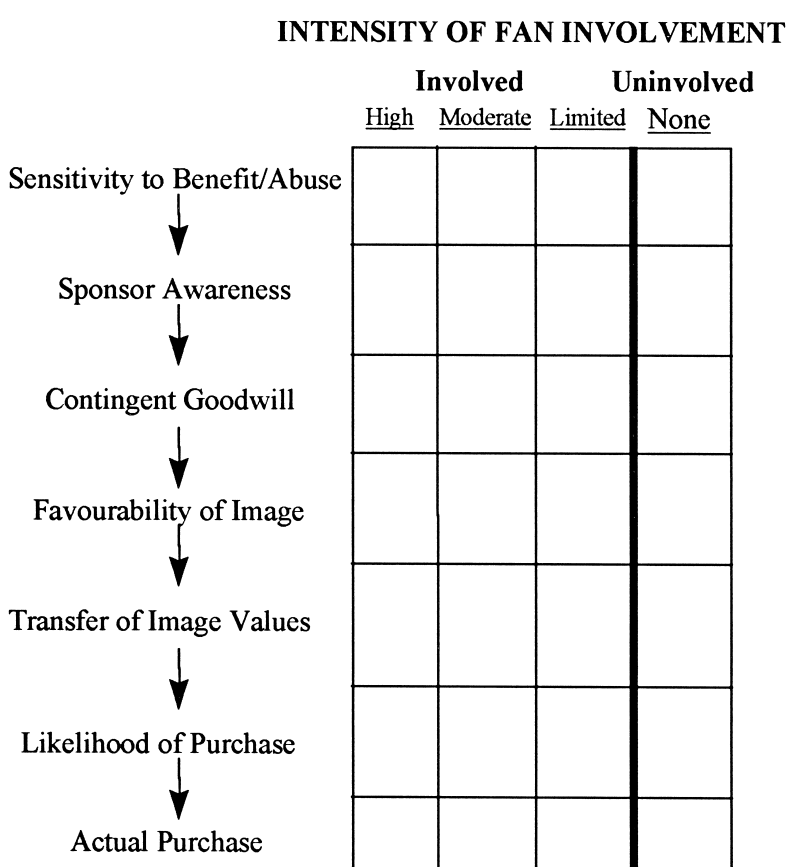

Figure 7. Activity involvement and sponsorship effects.

MODELING SPONSORSHIP EFFECTS

Having examined the tenets of goodwill, image transfer, and fan involvement in sponsorship and their integration in terms of consumer response, it is possible to suggest a model that provides a basis for understanding the effects of sponsorship on consumers. Essentially, the model indicated in Figure 8 suggests that although the consumer is preconditioned by both the generic and category effects of sponsorship, consumer response to sponsorship is fundamentally driven by the consumer's degree of involvement with and knowledge about the sponsored activity and the related extent of goodwill directed toward the sponsor.

High levels of knowledge about the activity arising from high activity involvement enables the fan/consumer to recognize the sponsor, judge the congruence of the relationship, and associate the image values of the activity (team or sport) onto the sponsor's brand, thereby enabling the sponsor to achieve the primary marketing objectives of awareness creation and brand image building.

Goodwill, which is a function of the perception of the sponsor's behavior toward the activity and the intensity of fan involvement with that activity, provides the trigger for the consumer's affective response and related behavior in terms of favorability, brand preference, and, in some instances, purchase.

Essentially, the proposed model suggests that sponsorship works differently on the consumer than does other forms of advertising and promotion in that it engages the consumer by bestowing benefit on an activity with which the consumer has an intensely emotional relationship. Perceived benefit generates a goodwill effect that acts as an emotional trigger to the achievement of particular consumer effects. The title of a recent conference (Hollis Directories, Ltd., 1998) "The Passionate Embrace—Stimulating Consumer Emotions through Sponsorship" captures the essence of the emotional trigger embodied in the sponsor–activity–fan relationship.

In considering the utility of the model as a guide to the management of sponsorship activity, it is important to recognize that it is most likely to apply in the following circumstances:

- Where an event/team/player is being sponsored rather than the broadcast of same (although many of the central principles still apply) (Bloxham 1995, 1998; Millman, 1995);
- Where a team/player is being sponsored rather than a competition (in that fan involvement toward a team/player is likely to be more intense);
- Where a single sponsor is clearly identified with an activity rather than where multiple sponsors compete for the available exposure and goodwill.

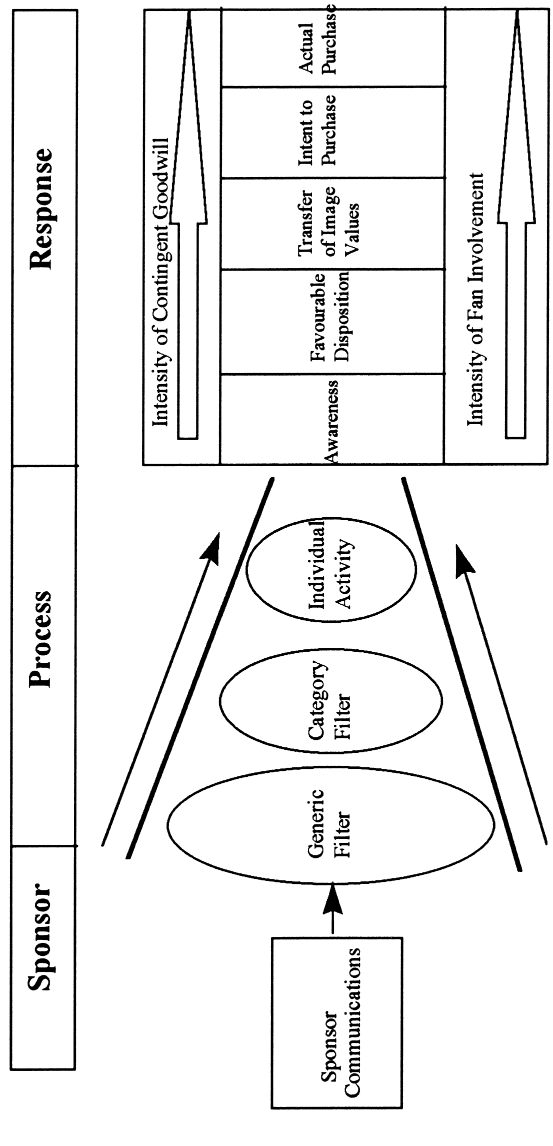

Figure 8. Modeling the sponsorship effects process.

SUMMARY

Understanding of the effects of sponsorship programs on consumers has hitherto largely been unavailable, a situation which stands in marked contrast to the current level of understanding operating in the related field of advertising. The purpose of this article has been to begin the process of redressing this imbalance in understanding by suggesting a model of sponsorship effects. The article sought to both identify and explore a number of important tenets, namely, goodwill in sponsorship, the process of image transfer, and the concept of fan involvement, as well as the integration of these tenets with the achievement of consumer response. This discussion led to the proposal of a comprehensive model to assist understanding of sponsorship effects.

The mapping of a route toward understanding of sponsorship effects, through the identification and classification of individual elements of understanding and more pertinently, through proposing a comprehensive overview of their interplay, may provide a guide to practitioners in their sponsorship decision making as well provide an important advance for academics on the road to deeper insight in this phenomenon.

This article has attempted to broaden the focus and raise the ambition of sponsorship studies by seeking a more comprehensive model of how sponsorship works. The importance of achieving such understanding cannot be overstated given the growth in importance of sponsorship and its likely future role in an evolving media, business, and social context.

This article has sought to set the terms of the research agenda and to shape aspects of the emerging debate. The objective of sponsorship research now must be to advance the studies in this important area of communications to at least the levels of understanding and sophistication achieved in the related field of advertising.

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